

**How Does Minimal or ‘Silent’ Branding in Luxury Fashion
Influence Consumer Perceptions of Exclusivity, and What Are the
Economic Effects of This Strategy on Brand Equity?**

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Abstract

This research explores the effect of subtle or 'silent' luxury fashion branding on consumer perceptions of exclusivity and the financial effect on brand valuation. As the luxury sector undergoes a cultural transformation, particularly among Millennials and Gen Z, conventional symbols of affluence—such as flashy logos and explicit branding—are replaced with more discreet, high-brow presentations of brand. This research employs a comparative, fact-based methodology to analyze six high-profile luxury brands: three under the umbrella of Silent Luxury (Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and Khaite) and three as Logo-Heavy Luxury (Gucci, Dior, and Louis Vuitton).

To measure and compare the effects of various branding strategies, two data-rich indicators were compared: mean five-year (2020–2025) worldwide consumer interest based on Google Trends and mean retail prices of women's handbags by brand. Findings indicate that, while Logo-Heavy brands maintain relatively higher levels of mean consumer interest (51.1 vs. 41.1), Silent Luxury brands have seen meteoric increases in cultural relevance and visibility over the last few years. More significantly, Silent Luxury brands command much higher mean product prices (\$6,011 vs. \$4,423), reflecting higher perceived value and desirability among consumers.

The study concludes that stealth branding is an upper-tier social signal, appealing to high-end and culturally sophisticated consumers who value discretion and individual identity over mass visibility. This change mirrors more general consumer values prioritizing authenticity, sustainability, and restrained exclusivity. Finally, the research shows that reduced branding is not only efficient in boosting brand equity but also an enduring strategy for luxury brands looking to align with changing consumer expectations and market forces.

1. Introduction: The Quiet Revolution in Luxury Branding

1.1 The Shifting Paradigm of Luxury Consumption

Luxury, previously characterized by showy visuals, blatant status symbols, and the in-your-face visibility of wealth, is caught in a cultural and generational shift. Understated design, subtlety-driven exclusivity, and emotional connection are becoming the new drivers of luxury consumption in the current market. The change is a result of shifting consumer perceptions towards self-expression, digital identity, and value-driven consumption habits. Millennials and Gen Z, who are now responsible for a considerable percentage of global luxury consumption, are demonstrating an increasingly diminishing interest in blatant displays of wealth, opting for authenticity, sustainability, and aesthetics based on simplicity and craftsmanship (Deloitte, 2023).

Within this changing consumer environment, dominant values like individuality, privacy, and moral consumption are supplanting classic symbols of luxury and affluence. Consumers now look more for self-describing products that communicate their own self and style of life, rather than merely announcing status (Su et al., 2022). This subtle shift has been occurring alongside global forces like digital oversaturation, economic division, and environmental awareness, which collectively have fostered a global aspiration for substantial and significant consumption (Rawas et al., 2022). Young consumers in high-growth markets like China prefer short-term partnerships and experimental releases, often for the purpose of generating distinctive moments of cultural and personal significance, affirming the shift away from traditional notions of luxury and towards carefully crafted differentiation (Zhou et al., 2023).

With this culture of discretion now the norm, increasingly luxury brand segments are responding by embracing "quiet" or "silent" branding strategies that eschew logos and bold

visual signals in favor of understated, detail-driven minimalism. This redefinition is now permeating every aspect of all tiers of luxury from product design and marketing strategies to shop environments and price architecture.

1.2 Defining Minimal Branding and Its Emergence in Luxury Fashion

Minimal branding, or "quiet luxury" or "stealth wealth," is a restraint-based, timelessness-focused, and understated branding approach. In contrast to conventional branding, which is dependent on overtly obvious visual cues such as monograms, colors, and large logos, minimal branding is restraint-based. It communicates high value as a more superior build, tactile subtlety, fewer design elements, and long-lasting aesthetics—often only intelligible to extremely well-informed or fashion-conscious consumers (Ingrid, 2023). In this case, it is not the logo that makes the bag elite but the manner in which the leather is treated, how well the stitching is hidden, or how sculptural the silhouette looks.

The Row, Loro Piana, Jil Sander, and Phoebe Philo's Céline are some of the brands that have pioneered silent luxury, providing products that communicate to the sophisticated customer who proclaims status not in showmanship but in understatement (Bertrandias et al., 2023). Bottega Veneta summed up this philosophy in its own motto, "When your own initials are enough," promoting identification on the basis of product excellence and not brand iconography.

The advent of this model of branding coincides with wider industry trends—ranging from the advent of slow fashion, the death of logo-fatigue, and the growth of second-hand and circular consumption—all converging on a paradigm shift in favor of longevity, taste, and purpose as the prime drivers of luxury consumption (Ahmed et al., 2022). Though times are social media-mediated, paradoxically, discretion and invisibility are new forms of digital visibility, as the

sharing of an unbranded minimalist product communicates a more subtle and sophisticated status message than logo-saturated alternatives.

1.3 Research Objectives and Significance

This research paper aims to examine the influence of minimalist or 'silent' branding on consumer perceptions of exclusivity and how this, in turn, influences the economic dimensions of brand equity in the luxury fashion market. Several studies have established that minimalist branding evokes greater emotional involvement, greater brand attachment, and perhaps greater customer lifetime value (Rawas et al., 2022). Further, analytical reviews of luxury brand portfolios illustrate a negative correlation between product price and brand visibility, with the suggestion that the absence of explicit branding actually serves to build greater consumer-perceived value and pricing power (Deloitte, 2023; Ingrid, 2023).

The psychological mechanisms behind this are most essential to understand. Consumers interpret silent branding as insider signalling, wherein they are able to be culturally fluent and socially competent without appearing arrogant. This form of exclusivity—attuned to understatement rather than conspicuousness—reshuffles the social differentiation and identity-formation mechanisms in consumer space (Bertrandias et al., 2023).

In addition to these perceptual consequences, the present study also explores the tangible business consequences of silent branding strategies. These encompass pricing model consequences, counterfeiting risks, resale performance, brand longevity, and market segmentation strategies.

2. Literature Review

2.1 The Evolution of Luxury Branding and Minimalism

Luxury branding has traditionally been driven by the law of conspicuous consumption, where visible design and logo positioning have been used as key indicators of wealth and status (Shukla et al., 2023). Based on pioneering theories like Veblen's "conspicuous consumption" theory, initial luxury branding strategies openly equated exclusivity with visibility and recognizability (Veblen, 1899). Louis Vuitton, Gucci, and Versace established their reputations on such products as monogram motifs and overt logo display, turning ornaments into status symbols globally (Pedro et al., 2024).

But as social norms evolved, luxury consumption has become increasingly intertwined with shifting concepts of identity, individuality, and cultural sophistication. Research shows a shift in generations—from display of wealth for the sake of wealth to seeking a more meaningful expression on the basis of discretion and authenticity (Currid-Halkett, 2017). The last few years have witnessed a dominant trend towards "quiet luxury" or "silent branding," where exclusivity is less expressed through overt signifiers and more through subtle signals such as material quality, asceticism of form, scarcity, and narrative (Kooli, 2024; McKinsey, 2024).

This is a reflection of broad socioeconomic and digital changes. Post-recession anxieties of 2008 and popular pressure against flashiness have driven luxury towards subtlety, and digital saturation and logo fatigue have worked towards the rise of minimalist fashions (McKinsey, 2024; Bertrandias et al., 2023). Luxury minimalist fashion brands such as Jil Sander, The Row, and Loro Piana have gained fervent allegiance by eschewing flashy logos in favor of narrative-dense quality, meticulous craftsmanship, and timeless style (Rajiv Gopinath, 2025).

2.2 Psychological Drivers of Silent Branding: Luxury as Social Signal

Minimal branding's attraction is necessarily linked to evolving consumer psychologies and social signaling processes. "Invisible luxury" is a type of so-called "inconspicuous consumption" as defined by Currid-Halkett (2017), whereby cultural capital, taste, and knowledge serve as the new markers of elite status. Ownership of minimally branded products is more likely to convey insider fluency—being "in the know" so to speak, rather than attempting to signal one's means to the maximum possible audience (Shukla et al., 2023; Pedro et al., 2024).

Empirical studies have established that high-end and culturally attuned consumers interpret subtle cues, including hand-cutting, own-brand fabrics, and discrete codes (e.g., Bottega Veneta's Intrecciato weave or Hermès' restrained lock), as being more elite than flashy logos (Kooli, 2024). Subtle cues are valued as they cannot be easily interpreted by the uninitiated, allowing customers to produce an air of mystery and selective social identification (Rajiv Gopinath, 2025).

The latest research indicates that emotional luxury value is as significant as functional value, and that subtle branding enhances emotional bonding by means of the experience of discovery, closeness, and personal relevance (Akarsu, 2025). It is particularly significant for Millennials and Gen Z, whose luxury is founded on personal experiences, moral congruence, and the desire to express, and not acquire, status (Kang, 2022).

2.3 Minimalism, Authenticity, and Brand Coolness

Literature unequivocally indicates that with decreasing overt visibility, consumer sentiments regarding brand desirability, 'coolness', and authenticity improve. Shukla et al. (2023) established that very conspicuous logos evoke negative sentiments regarding brand authenticity

and 'coolness' particularly among discerning luxury consumers. Not only do "patrician" consumers (most informed and richest groups) favor subtle cues and soft signals, but overall, the trend in markets is towards weariness with overt branding (Shukla et al., 2023; Berger and Ward, 2010).

Kooli (2024) tested these hypotheses experimentally in a series of direct comparisons between consumer responses to "quiet" and "loud" luxury products, with and without sustainability communications. Subtly branded products were rated consistently more exclusive, authentic, and desirable than strongly branded equivalents by participants. Experimental manipulation checks were strong: minimal/quiet stimuli were rated consistently less showy and more elegant (Kooli, 2024). Products with minimal branding and sustainability communications topped exclusivity and willingness to pay scales, an entry into a "new language of luxury" based on silent signaling and intentional value. These results are consistent with market study research findings that record consumer preferences strongly moving towards minimalism in today's digitally mediated, oversaturated fashion climate. In the McKinsey Global Fashion Report, 65% of today's luxury consumers cite "subtlety of design" over brand name as their first choice, and fashion brands utilizing minimalist strategies have recorded greater loyalty and retention than those utilizing logo-based strategies (Rajiv Gopinath, 2025).

2.4 Economic Implications: Brand Equity, Pricing, and Retention

Synergy between low-branding, perceived exclusivity, and economic value is currently being researched and pursued by researchers and managers. University research and consulting research agree on a number of key findings:

Firstly, it has been shown that price and logo conspicuity are negatively correlated, and that stealth-branded products of brands like Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and The Row often have greater average prices than overtly branded counterparts (Deloitte, 2023; Kooli, 2024; Rajiv Gopinath, 2025).

Secondly, low-key branding contributes to underlying factors of brand equity like loyalty, emotional attachment, and perceived differentiation. Absence of logos or conspicuous branding paradoxically contributes to the "signal value" of products among the most valuable segments, especially when the luxury market evolves from boasting wealth to signaling membership and exclusion (Kooli, 2024).

Kooli (2024) research, for example, determined that repurchase intentions and willingness to pay were strongest for products with low branding combined with high-quality stories of craftsmanship and sustainability. This is clear from the fact that luxury brands embracing minimalist strategies have 18% greater customer retention and positive long-term economic outcomes (McKinsey, 2024).

Third, subtle branding is increasingly popular with e-commerce. The more luxury retail goes digital, the more brands and retailers look to leverage data-driven personalization and thoughtfully created narrative to deliver "high-touch" experiences that reinforce exclusivity and emotional bonds (Ingrid, 2023).

Lastly, silent branding has the benefits of resilience and risk management. Brash logos are common targets for counterfeiting—watering down both perceived rarity and authentic brand value. By transitioning to less copyable, more quietly expressed design features, brands such as

Hermès and Goyard have gained more protection for their essential identity and rarefied standing (Bertrandias et al., 2023; Rajiv Gopinath, 2025).

2.5 Cross-Cultural and Generational Perspectives

Even as global migration toward minimalist branding is occurring, significant differences persist in consumer reaction by generation and geography. In fast-changing markets like China, for instance, the rise of minimal luxury is paired with a ravenous appetite for one-off collaborations and hyper-personalized branded moments (Su et al., 2022). Zhou et al. (2023) discover that Chinese young adults are driven not only by scarcity but also by social and online visibility, sometimes prioritizing limited-edition collaborations over eternal minimalism. This is a broader trend: as meaning in luxury becomes more layered, savvy brands need to weigh their understated branding strategies against local codes and generational sensibilities while maintaining an overarching global thread.

Furthermore, social constructionist studies prove that luxury brand value and meaning are actually negotiated by designers and consumers over time through interaction (Pedro et al., 2024). Designers' satisfaction and brand vision consistency can, in turn, affect consumers' perceptions of luxury and exclusivity—i.e., silent branding is not only a tactic but an entire management strategy regarding internal culture and external communication (Pedro et al., 2024).

2.6 Holistic Brand Strategy: Challenges and Limitations

While minimalist branding is an international trend and lucrative, the strategy is not without its dangers. There are dangers of genericism or misinterpretation—without clear signals of differentiation, some consumers may skip or underprice minimally branded products (Deloitte, 2023). The fine line between invisibility and recognizability compels brands to create extremely

subtle narratives, invest in material innovation, and build genuine communities of enthusiasts (Kooli, 2024).

Moreover, as fashion information increasingly democratized by the internet, formerly niche signals of taste can become mass, sometimes reducing the very insider appeal that motivated their adoption (Bertrandias et al., 2023). What this is stating is that the exclusivity arms race goes on, with luxury brands having to continually reinvent and refine their minimalist brand signals.

2.7 Synthesis and Research Gap

Lastly, the literature confirms that the success of minimalist or silent branding in luxury fashion relies on macro trends—economic, psychological, and cultural—that value signaling, storytelling, and self-facing fulfillment over external display. Pioneering research, particularly Kooli (2024), has confirmed the connection between brand minimalism, perceived distinctiveness, and improved economic performance, and thus forms the solid foundation for further research.

However, as luxury shifts away from hierarchical signaling toward cultural belonging and identity work, additional multi-method research is required to explore the nuances across regions, digital touchpoints, and product categories. The subsequent sections therefore examine, empirically and conceptually, how less-is-more branding recalibrates the math of exclusivity and brand equity for luxury fashion in contemporary consumer markets.

3. Theoretical Framework

A multidisciplinary theoretical approach is required to identify the impact of subtle or 'silent' consumption of luxury fashion brands on consumer perceptions of exclusivity and the monetary value of brand equity. This involves incorporating ideas from signaling theory, conspicuous and inconspicuous consumption theory, minimalism design philosophy, and economic theory of consumer behavior in status markets.

Signaling theory gives a core explanation of luxury consumption. Luxury items in the past served as status symbols, conveying prosperity, prestige, and belonging to upper social classes through explicitly visible brand characteristics. Traditional explanation, borrowed from Veblen's theory of conspicuous consumption, proposes that people consume publicly visible goods to convey socio-economic superiority (Veblen, 1899). Luxury branding has traditionally drawn on conspicuous logos, recognizable prints, and extensive advertising to convey value and selectivity to the masses.

Yet, inconspicuous consumption themes have come to the fore in recent decades, as meaning and mechanism of status signaling have shifted. Currid-Halkett (2017) suggested that in the era of cultural capital, affluent consumers have moved away from explicit status displays, opting for subtle or even invisible signs of taste, education, and lifestyle compatibility. This is especially true among the highly educated, culturally aware audience, who now gain status from knowledge-based consumption — enjoying cues that are unavailable or nonsensical to the uninformed masses.

In luxury fashion, this is reflected in the fashion for low-key or tacit branding, where the very absence of overt logos is a sign in itself. The tacit style of a The Row bag or the expensive

quality of a Loro Piana cashmere scarf communicates connoisseurship not in overt branding but in craftsmanship, rarity, and material quality — qualities legible only to those with the cultural capital to recognize the prestige and tradition of the brand. This is also aligned with Bourdieu's theory of "distinction," where taste preference is a marker of class and social identity (Bourdieu, 1984). Here, the ability to read "silent" branding is itself a social marker, distinguishing insiders from outsiders.

Theory has quantified how such dynamics operate in the counterfeiting and market saturation world. Liu, Yildirim and Zhang (2014) developed a minimalist luxury model that proposed when luxury logos are ubiquitous or easily imitated through counterfeiting, upscale consumers strategically adopt minimal branding as a strategic response to maintain exclusivity. Their model demonstrates that, in a world of counterfeiting, removing conspicuous brand signals actually raises the social value of a product among the targeted luxury consumers. The signaling equilibrium thus shifts: less branding generates more distinction, as fewer can decipher the value being signaled.

Empirical support for such models is on the horizon. Kooli's (2024) experimental study demonstrated that consumers rated minimally branded luxury brands as much more elite, sophisticated, and aspirational than their highly logoed counterparts. Study participants consistently associated "quiet" luxury brands with higher personal identity fit, craftsmanship, and discretion. Moreover, when minimal branding was paired with sustainability storytelling, consumer willingness-to-pay increased substantially — a sign that luxury brand value in the current era is not solely in exclusivity but in purpose-driven narrative. Manipulation checks in the study confirm that minimalism was not merely perceived by participants but positively interpreted as an expression of first-class positioning. These findings support signaling theory

through today's evidence and further expand our knowledge on how silent branding communicates values like authenticity, ethical practice, and corporate social responsibility.

Minimalism also aids brand positioning through its visual structure, in accordance with design principles of simplicity, order, timelessness, and restraint. Minimalism in luxury fashion is not absence of effort or restriction of creativity but speaks of refined quality and thoughtful design choices. Minimal styles, according to Pangarkar et al. (2021), are highly connected with consumer views of long-term quality and smart purchasing, which in turn are connected with consumer satisfaction and loyalty. This has strong implications for brand equity. Silent branding facilitates close emotional bonds through establishment of perceptions of closeness, exclusivity, and shared values between the consumer and the brand. This, in the long run, creates higher customer retention and brand advocacy, which benefits the economic and cultural capital of the brand.

Furthermore, in a virtual shopping space where customer identity is increasingly built upon constructed online identities, silent luxury branding enables consumers to be distinctive without necessarily proclaiming affluence. Ingrid (2023) discovers that e-commerce digital personalization strategies are increasingly narrative and product experience-driven rather than visual brand-driven, and therefore exclusivity is an internalized, personalized status cue and less performative. In this, consumer meaning-making of brand deservingness is increasingly tied to intrinsic product attributes and common meanings and less visual recognition alone.

Silent branding also changes the way value is conveyed and perceived from a brand equity perspective. Traditional brand equity models are concerned with recognizability, trust, quality perceptions, and loyalty (Aaker, 1991). Minimal branding contradicts these assumptions by reducing explicit recognition and maximizing symbolic significance, cultural connection, and

emotional attachment. A brand-less product with exceptional craftsmanship can be granted more loyalty and create more pride of ownership simply because of the subtle, unobtrusive beauty it brings to a niche market.

Therefore, this research assumes a multi-layered theory: luxury consumption is usually conceived as social signaling, increasingly complicated by minimalist design, strategic invisibility, and subtle cultural identification. By situating branding choices within these changing paradigms of perception, distinction, and value, we can better grasp the function of minimal branding as an intermediary of consumer reaction and economic performance in today's luxury fashion economies.

4. Methodology and Results

4.1 Research Framework and Objectives

This study employs a comparative, exploratory research design to examine the relationship between branding visibility and perceived exclusivity and economic value of luxury fashion products. With increased focus on the impact minimalist or 'silent' branding approaches have on consumer behavior and perception in the marketplace, this study attempts to place figures on the impact these varying approaches have by examining real-world data. Its purpose is two-fold: first, to examine whether silent luxury brands are of more or less interest to consumers than logo heavy luxury brands; second, to determine whether these branding approaches are associated with measurable differences in product price, with a specific interest in women's handbags as a product category proxy.

With the aim of determining the success factors for these luxury brands, the research studies a well-chosen sample of six internationally renowned luxury fashion businesses. These

are categorized into two groups according to their shared branding strategy. The first group comprises Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and Khaite, each renowned for its presence in the luxury sector for adhering to the minimalist strategy and an overt lack of overt logos. The second group comprises Gucci, Dior, and Louis Vuitton—businesses traditionally linked to logo-centered, overtly branded advertising campaigns. These six businesses were selected due to their international presence, fashion influence on consumers, and active participation within the luxury handbag market.

The study targets the women's handbags product category due to their symbolic status in luxury consumption. Handbags are generally known as status-symbolic products, and they embody a clear indication of a brand's design language, aesthetic reasoning, and market positioning. Second, handbags are usually the entry point for customers who are new to the luxury industry, and their price point is usually consistent with other brand moves that are designed for exclusivity and segmentation of customers. On these premises, the product category offers a grounded basis for the exploration of tensions between logo-dominant and silent branding and market repercussions.

4.2 Data Collection and Analytical Approach

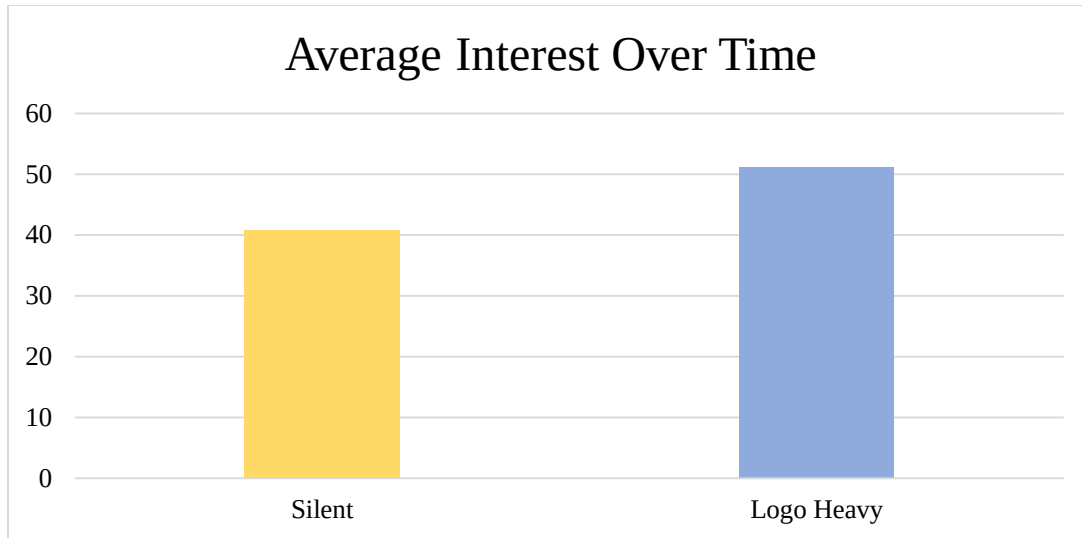
To quantify consumer perception as reflected in overall interest and attention, this study uses publicly available and normalized data provided by Google Trends. Google Trends has widespread use in industry and academia for temporal analysis of global digital interest. Search interest was tracked weekly for each brand in the study sample for five years from 2020 to 2025. Google Trends operates by providing a relative value between 0 and 100 to all search terms to represent relative popularity over the chosen time period and geographic location. Data were analyzed globally without category filtering to encompass the broadest possible set of data and

minimize region bias. Average interest values over the five-year period were computed for each individual brand and means were then computed within group means for both brand groups—silent and logo-heavy.

The second primary dataset relates to the economic aspect of branding strategy—i.e., average women's handbag retail price. Prices were obtained from official brand websites of the individual brands. The sampling approach was to select a combination of flagship and best-seller products to obtain a representative average price per brand. Prices were U.S. dollar-converted and were full retail prices, not discounted or promotional price-adjusted. The window for the data was aligned with the Google Trends window to ensure temporal equivalence across interest and financial data. Analysis was by a combination of aggregate measures and longitudinal observation across time.

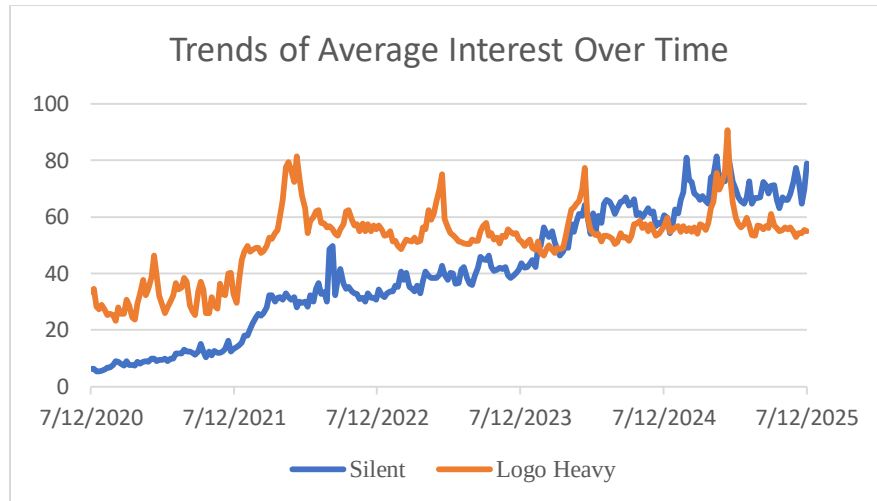
4.3 Interest Over Time: Interpreting the Google Trends Data

The Google Trends data indicate that logo-dominant luxury brands, in absolute global search volume, convey slightly more aggregate interest than silent luxury brands. Over the five-year period in question, the logo-dominant segment (Gucci, Dior, and Louis Vuitton) averaged a global interest score of 51.1, whereas the silent luxury segment (Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and Khaite) averaged a slightly lower value of 41.1. These values would seem to add up, at an initial glance, in support of traditional branding strategies emphasizing logos and visual identity as still enjoying wider public awareness and global internet visibility.



Data Source: Google Trends (World wide data from 2020-2025)

But a longitudinal examination of the data presents a more dynamic view. Although logo-led brands were more prevalent in the earlier half of the observation interval—namely, from 2020 to 2022—it was apparent that consumers' interest in quiet luxury brands had risen considerably in more recent years. Beginning around 2023, there is an obvious trend of increased attention to quiet luxury brands, with occasional spikes that approach or even surpass the visibility of the logo-led brands. For example, Bottega Veneta experienced colossal spikes in search volume during the times that it released high-profile but low-key collections that emphasized craftsmanship and restraint in design. Similarly, social media storytelling around "old money" looks and minimalist fashion has driven increased interest in brands that embody those principles.



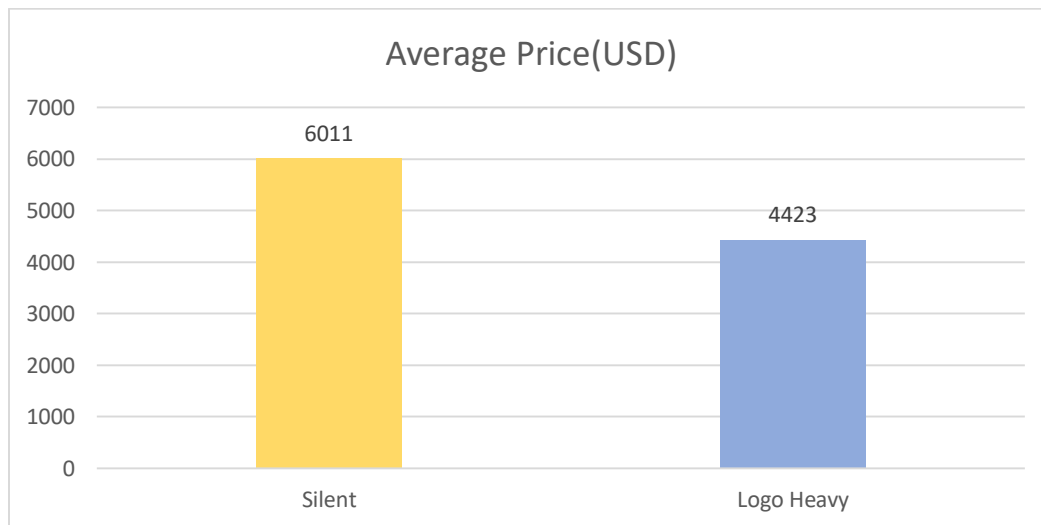
Data Source: Google Trends (World wide data from 2020-2025)

This changing trend is a piece of a broader cultural transformation, especially among Millennial and Generation Z consumers, who are similarly drawn to restraint rather than showiness, experience, and authenticity (Kooli, 2024). Silent luxury appears to be growing not only as a subtrend but as a new fashion norm of signaling, one that is appealing to consumers who see discretion and refinement as modern markers of status. The growing Google Trends search popularity of quiet luxury brands supports recent work in fashion consumer behavior in which minimalism is valued for its ability to signal taste, sustainability, and discrimination (Deloitte, 2023; Bertrandias et al., 2023).

4.4 Pricing Patterns: A Window into Brand Equity

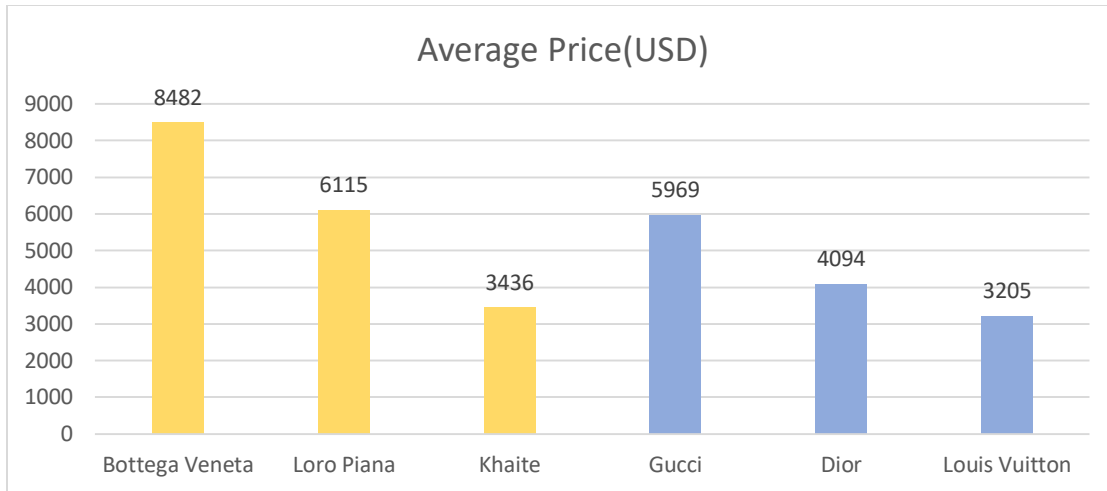
A review of the price information illustrates a consistent and significant difference between the two groups. Among the silent luxury brands in question, Bottega Veneta averages \$8,482 per handbag (Bottega Veneta, 2025), Loro Piana averages \$6,115 per handbag (Loro Piana, 2025), and Khaite averages \$3,436 per handbag (Khaite, 2025). This averages to a silent luxury group price of \$6,011. Comparatively, handbag prices for the Gucci average

\$5,969(Gucci,2025), Dior average \$4,094(Dior,2025), and Louis Vuitton average \$3,205(Louis Vuitton), combining to average \$4,423 in a group. The price differential—approximately \$1,589—illustrates a significant difference, reflecting that silent luxury brands overall pay more for similar products.



Data Source: Individual websites of the above-mentioned brands

These numbers tell us several things about how branding tactics convert into economic value. While logo-centric brands enjoy the benefits of established recognizability and solid heritage connections, silent luxury brands leverage their developed aura of invisibility and selectivity to command greater retail prices. Consumers who participate with silent luxury brands are buying something greater than a product; they are buying what the lack of a logo signifies: greater quality, exclusivity by discretion, and a kind of social knowledge that is supra-visible.



Data Source: Individual websites of the above-mentioned brands

This finding confirms the findings of Kooli's (2024) experimental study, in which the consumer was more ready to pay for minimally branded products—particularly when paired with sustainability marks. Minimalism, therefore, renders an item more exclusive in perceived terms, not by rendering it invisible, but by rendering its value readable only by those within a given culture field. In luxury terms, this is the transition from "look what I own" to "only those who know, know what I own."

The price trend observed also supports Liu, Yildirim, and Zhang's (2014) minimalist luxury theoretical model, which postulates that the role of branding visibility shifts in logo- and counterfeiting-rich worlds. In such worlds, consumers increasingly demand unique and exclusive signals, such as texture, silhouette, tailoring, or origin. Logos being easily copied, luxury consumers turn to tacit design signifiers that are hard to replicate but instantly readable to other insiders. Silent luxury's premium price is therefore a result of its greater signaling efficiency among the cognoscenti.

In addition, these price effects also reinforce and reflect brand equity. Qualitative attitude and secondary value in equity measurement models play a big role. Implicit luxury brands skirting mass appeal through understatement paradoxically enhance their appeal to fashion's most lucrative niches. The high-end prices of Bottega Veneta or Loro Piana handbags thus not only result from cost of production but also from established identity, psychological value, and restricted social accessibility.

4.5 Combined Interpretation of Interest and Pricing

Together, the price and interest data demonstrate a radical shift in the luxury branding dynamics. Whereas traditionally branding power meant visibility, the 2020s have witnessed the pendulum swinging in the direction of identity and intimacy. That modestly lower average public visibility of quietly luxury brands is sufficient to command far greater prices attests that economic value in luxury is no longer a question of reach or recognizability but of perceived exclusivity, cultural capital, and excellence in craftsmanship.

The success of quiet luxury brands in attracting consumer attention the past two years means that being subtle is not a weakness in the age of the internet; instead, it is redefined as an indicator of strategic sophistication. Consumers prefer to deal with brands that speak a language of bespoke luxury—where materiality and subjective nature of consumption are preferred over dazzling others.

The silent luxury value premium reflects a strong ability to create brand equity on the basis of new consumer values. Strategically, this indicates that understated branding is no longer a specialty play but a potential mainstream positioning for attracting high-end, sophisticated, and quality-conscious consumers. Aesthetic simplicity is being more lucratively leveraged than

complexity in some product categories, illustrating that silence is as golden in simile as it is in price worth.

In summary, the results of this study affirm that the pervasiveness of branding has genuine effects on consumer perception and economic value. Silent luxury branding allows the build-up of refined exclusivity, and whereas logo-laden brands reap wider awareness, silent brands might be building the next level of what is luxury. To be able to command high-sale prices and also gain digital momentum indicates a new equilibrium where branding is not lost but strategically understated—a silent communication that speaks volumes.

5. Discussion

The results of this study offer robust support for the evolving dynamics of luxury brand positioning, with high correlation between branding strategy—silent vs. logo-intensive—and proxy indicators of brand equity such as consumer interest and price power. The evidence offers a richly textured picture of the modern luxury consumer, who is more particular in their desire for discretion, cultural capital, and signs of authentic identity over recognizability at mass and overt signaling of status. The results confirm that the symbolic vocabulary of luxury is in fact undergoing a radical transformation, and that silent branding is no longer seen as understated, but as a more sophisticated expression within elite consumption culture.

Up to now, logos and icon imagery were the most important tools of luxury branding, allowing consumers to position themselves within pre-existing social hierarchies of taste and prosperity (Veblen, 1899). But this present research confirms that earlier research had already intimated—that such "signaling through visibility" was being replaced by "signaling through invisibility" (Currid-Halkett, 2017; Liu et al., 2014). Although logo-studded brands such as

Gucci, Dior, and Louis Vuitton continue to have strong brand recognition, especially among global consumer clusters, the recent, sudden surge of interest in quiet luxury brands such as Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and Khaite over the past five years indicates a fierce cultural and generational shift.

By holding the Google Trends data against current branding theory, it can be seen that mass interest in silent luxury brands is more than fleeting consumer interest—it is the expression of a new, more intimate connection between user and brand. The relatively small difference in the average interest scores of the two groups (with logo-branding brands at 51.1 and silent luxury at 41.1) is vastly less important than the trend of convergence over time. Silent brands have bridged the gap and, in some windows of time, actually outrank their louder relatives in visibility. This is evident in support of the theory that consumer interest is not simply a function of recognizability, but is increasingly a response to subtlety, perceived authenticity, and personal identity alignment (Kooli, 2024).

Maybe the most obvious separator of the two brand categories is the average price of their handbags. Mean prices of silent luxury brands are considerably higher than those of their logo-centric peers—a gap of nearly \$1,600 per bag. This finding confirms what recent research has suggested: that reduced or 'silent' branding enhances consumers' beliefs in rarity (Shukla et al., 2023; Bertrandias et al., 2023). Silent luxury brands' price premium is not the product of shallow market positioning; rather, it is a reflection of genuine value attached by consumers to quality, understatement, and insider status.

Luxury goods have for centuries been employed to convey wealth and status, according to signaling theory. But as signaling environments change—because of ubiquitous logo oversaturation, counterfeiting threats, or mass-market availability of 'luxury' products—consumers

desire more discreet and less obvious signifiers (Liu et al., 2014). Under such circumstances, logos are ineffective and are diluted. Minimal branding, conversely, becomes a high-order cultural code. It's a way of signaling status to a savvy audience—those with the cultural literacy to appreciate subtle craftsmanship, finest materials, and iconic silhouettes without obvious branding.

The premium prices of quiet luxury handbags imply that the consumer attributes a higher symbolic value to the products. Being unable to identify the brand by sight is a component of the product's mystique, a component very much rooted in insider culture. This aligns with Bourdieu's distinction theory, whereby individuals gain taste-based differences in order to distinguish themselves from mainstream or "vulgarized" consumption (Bourdieu, 1984). Silent luxury brands offer a distinction device that is less performative and more self-generated, confirming the buyer's sense of individual discrimination and upward mobility through knowledge rather than naked wealth.

Even as visibility remains a powerful force for most well-established brands, the price margin suggests diminishing marginal returns to overt branding. In an era where younger consumers value discretion and sustainability over spectacle, invisibility for a brand can be a wonderful thing. Consumers who pay a premium to buy something without a logo are not purchasing anonymity but greater identity. They are communicating that they are part of an elite group whose familiarity of luxury codes extends beyond mass-market visibility.

In addition to conceptual reframing, this study also has relevance for the manner in which exclusivity is being constructed by luxury brands today. Price exclusions and scarcity have long been the drivers of exclusivity, but increasingly, it is being constructed through narrative, subtlety, and customer experience (Ingrid, 2023). Personalization via e-commerce and data-

driven recommend systems enable luxury companies to connect with consumers in personal, meaningful ways—yet another expression of the shift away from public display towards private, emotional connection.

Particularly, what the evidence here verifies are Kooli's (2024) findings that individuals do not all need awareness of logos in order to acknowledge status. As Kooli's experiment established, brands with little in the way of design and rich narratives of sustainability and craftsmanship were all perceived as more aspirational and elite. The same principles apply in the market behaviors of silent luxury brands whose value is enhanced by their storytelling, design restraint, and commitment to ethical consumption values.

But whereas silent branding appears to be overtaking logo-dense branding on some economic measures, the model has its limitations. One of them is accessibility. The "if you know, you know" silent luxury paradigm may shut out newer or younger consumers just discovering luxury products. The absence of explicit brand signifiers can neuter status validation or thrill for consumers who wish to signal rapidly or broadly across social universes. Which is why logo-dense brands remain of enormous significance in some niches of the luxury market, particularly in niches like streetwear-adjacent apparel, influencer culture, or neighborhood markets where logos are aspirational and not ostentatious.

Further, the price differential between the two levels demonstrates both the feasibility of low-profile branding and the ephemeral nature of such trends. As silent luxury turns into a culture trend, business firms relying on invisibility alone will eventually be plagued by differentiation, standardization, or overextension issues. In highly saturated marketplaces, the visual cues of logo-based branding typically are effective recall and loyalty cues among

consumers. Yet silent luxury brands need to ensure that their mystique is experiential and based on product superiority and not visual restraint alone.

Managerially, these findings underscore the importance of brand strategy to keep up with target consumers' driving values and shifting expectations. For established logo-driven brands, the challenge will be striking balance between familiarity and restraint—how to maintain core brand codes while offering streamlined substitutes to emerging luxury consumers. For silent luxury brands, the challenge will be expanding without diluting authenticity, maintaining their mystique of curation while reaching out.

In short, the implications of this research confirm that luxury consumer values are changing. Status is no longer communicated through visibility, but through exclusivity, subtlety, meaning, self-awareness, and discerning choice. Silence branding is not the lack of branding, but rather a new type of signifier—one based on merit, proximity, and membership, instead of spectacle, copying, and display. Because younger generations of consumers increasingly crave more honest forms of identity and self-expression, softly spoken brands are likely to be the ones screaming the loudest.

6. Conclusion

The aim of this study has been to examine the influence of low or 'silent' branding in luxury fashion on consumer perceptions of exclusivity and the financial implications this creates for brand value. Using a comparative methodology, the study compared six globally recognized luxury brands—divided into two groups, Silent Luxury and Logo-Heavy Luxury—according to branding salience. Using five years of Google Trends data to quantify consumer interest and

verified retail price data on women's handbags, this study has provided empirical evidence of the connection between branding strategy and public interest and market value.

The statistics show that although logo-centric brands have been more prominent on the web for years, this role is being increasingly challenged by the emergence of silent luxury. Over the past five years, silent luxury brands such as Bottega Veneta, Loro Piana, and Khaite have experienced a clear upward trend in global consumer demand, gradually closing the gap with or even surpassing more conventionally ostentatious brands such as Gucci, Dior, and Louis Vuitton. This is a larger cultural shift in luxury consumption, particularly among Millennial and Gen Z consumers who prioritize authenticity, subtlety, and craftsmanship over attention-grabbing exhibitions of affluence.

Furthermore, the price data corroborates the economic strength of silent branding. The silent luxury brand bags were found to have significantly higher average retail prices compared to their logo-centric counterparts despite slightly lower overall search interest. This would indicate that consumers associate low-key branding as an indicator of high quality and scarcity—a perception strong enough to justify a high price premium.

Combined, these trends indicate that silent or minimal branding is more than a trend but a potent positioning strategy for today's luxury industry. It allows brands to form stronger emotional connections with consumers, generate value through discretion and narrative, and command higher prices without losing exclusivity. In a world of more mindful consumption and identity-based shopping, silent branding is the future of luxury: one of meaning, intimacy, and distinction rather than spectacle or populism. As luxury brands spearhead the push into an increasingly changing marketplace, individuals who can comprehend and appreciate the

subtleties of silent signaling will be best positioned to create long-lasting brand equity and cultural resonance in the future.

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